

Chapter 1 — Memphy

The Vonne Pack had been traveling for hours.

Vonne walked near the front of the group, looking across the wide stretch of land ahead.

Beside him, Vonn was kicking small stones across the ground.

Sparkyle was walking backward.

Leafily kept looking around.

And Tulip—who the others sometimes called Lily—was quietly following behind them.

Sparkyle suddenly stopped.

“Guys.”

Nobody answered.

“Guys.”

Vonne looked back.

“What?”

Sparkyle pointed dramatically at the sky.

“I think I saw something.”

Vonn looked upward.

“You say that every time you see a bird.”

“That wasn't a bird.”

Tulip looked up.

“Where?”

“There!”

Something was flying across the sky.

It was fast.

Very fast.

It moved through the clouds for a moment before diving lower.

Leafily's eyes widened.

“That's a VONS!”

Vonne stared.

“It's flying.”

Vonn smiled.

“Okay. Now that's interesting.”

Sparkyle immediately started running.

“Let's follow it!”

Vonne sighed.

“Sparkyle—”

“COME ON!”

Tulip laughed.

“He's already gone.”

Leafily started running after him.

“Then we'd better catch up!”

Vonne looked at Vonn.

“You coming?”

Vonn grinned.

“Obviously.”

The whole group ran.

The flying VONS disappeared behind a distant hill.

Sparkyle reached the top first.

He stopped suddenly.

“Where did it go?”

Leafily caught up.

“You were supposed to watch where it went!”

“I was running!”

“That isn't an excuse!”

Vonn arrived next.

“I can see it.”

Everyone turned.

Far ahead, the mysterious VONS was flying toward a peninsula.

Vonne narrowed his eyes.

“Let's keep following.”

Tulip looked at the distance.

“That is pretty far.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“Good.”

Vonne stared at him.

“Why is that good?”

“Because if it were close, we'd already know who it was.”

Vonn laughed.

“That actually makes sense.”

“Thank you.”

“I wasn't complimenting you.”

Sparkyle's smile disappeared.

“Never mind.”

They continued.

After nearly an hour, the group was exhausted.

Sparkyle finally dropped onto the ground.

“I can't.”

Vonne stopped.

“What now?”

“I am officially finished.”

Vonn looked at him.

“You said that twenty minutes ago.”

“I meant it this time.”

Tulip sat beside him.

“You're still following us.”

Sparkyle looked at her.

“Because apparently I have terrible decision-making skills.”

Leafily laughed.

Then Vonn pointed ahead.

“There!”

Everyone looked.

The flying VONS had finally landed.

She was standing at the edge of the peninsula.

Her wings were folded.

She was looking toward the distant land.

Vonne raised a hand.

“Hello?”

The stranger turned.

She looked startled.

“Who are you?”

Vonne stepped forward.

“I'm Vonne.”

Vonn waved.

“I'm Vonn.”

Sparkyle raised both hands.

“Sparkyle.”

Leafily smiled.

“Leafily.”

Tulip gave a small wave.

“And I'm Tulip. Some people call me Lily.”

The stranger looked at all five of them.

Then she smiled.

“I'm Memphy.”

Vonne smiled.

“Nice to meet you, Memphy.”

“You too.”

Sparkyle looked at Memphy's wings.

“You were the one flying?”

Memphy laughed.

“Yes.”

“You were REALLY fast.”

“Thanks.”

Vonn stepped closer.

“How did you learn to fly like that?”

Memphy shrugged.

“I've been flying for a long time.”

Tulip looked impressed.

“You flew all the way over here?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Memphy's expression changed.

She looked toward the land.

“I was investigating something.”

Vonne noticed the change immediately.

“What happened?”

Memphy didn't answer.

Instead, she looked at all of them.

“Have you heard of Restate JR?”

The group became quiet.

Vonn's smile disappeared.

Sparkyle crossed his arms.

“Unfortunately.”

Leafily looked at Vonne.

Vonne nodded.

“We know the name.”

Memphy took a breath.

“Then you need to know what's happening here.”

Memphy led them to a rocky area overlooking the region.

From there, the Vonne Pack could see a huge stretch of land.

At first, it looked normal.

But once they looked carefully, they noticed smoke in the distance.

Some areas were damaged.

There were strange structures scattered across the landscape.

Tulip frowned.

“What happened here?”

Memphy pointed toward the land.

“Restate JR.”

Vonne looked at her.

“Tell us everything.”

Memphy nodded.

“Restate JR captured this entire region.”

Sparkyle frowned.

“For what?”

“To continue his father's legacy.”

Vonn looked surprised.

“Restate's son?”

“Yes.”

Leafily asked,

“Is he really that dangerous?”

Memphy looked at her.

“He is stronger than his father.”

Sparkyle's eyes widened.

“Stronger?”

Memphy nodded.

“The H.D.T. tried to stop him.”

Vonne asked,

“The Hallmark Defense Team?”

“Yes.”

“What happened?”

“They failed.”

The group went silent.

Vonn looked toward the distant smoke.

“How many times?”

“Several.”

“And Restate JR is still there?”

“Yes.”

Tulip clenched her fists.

“Then someone has to stop him.”

Memphy looked at her.

“That is exactly why I brought you here.”

Vonne turned toward Memphy.

“You knew we'd come?”

“No.”

“Then why us?”

Memphy smiled slightly.

“Because I've heard what the Vonne Pack has done before.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“Oh.”

Vonn looked at him.

“Don't.”

“What?”

“You're about to become annoying.”

“I was already annoying.”

Leafily laughed.

Memphy smiled.

“You've defeated Restate before.”

Vonne nodded.

“We did.”

“And now his son has taken his place.”

Vonn looked at Vonne.

“Sounds like we're dealing with the same problem again.”

Vonne shook his head.

“Not the same problem.”

He looked toward the damaged region.

“A bigger one.”

Memphy nodded.

“Exactly.”

Memphy continued explaining.

“Restate JR has filled the region with his forces.”

“What kind?” Sparkyle asked.

Memphy began counting.

“Bombelos.”

Vonn frowned.

“Those things are annoying.”

“Speedos.”

Tulip frowned.

“Fast ones?”

“Yes.”

“Hido's.”

Leafily looked confused.

“What's a Hido?”

“You'll find out.”

Sparkyle looked worried.

“That answer wasn't comforting.”

Memphy continued.

“Flingos.”

Vonne nodded.

“Expected.”

“Worms.”

Vonn looked at Sparkyle.

“Definitely expected.”

“Flamines.”

Leafily's expression changed.

“Those sound dangerous.”

“They are.”

“Spikes.”

Tulip sighed.

“Of course.”

“And General Flingos.”

Sparkyle stared.

“Wait.”

Memphy looked at him.

“What?”

“You said **General Flingos**.”

“Yes.”

“That's an actual thing?”

“Yes.”

Sparkyle looked at Vonne.

“I don't like this mission anymore.”

Vonne smiled.

“You never liked the mission.”

“I liked it before she listed the army!”

Memphy laughed.

Vonne looked at Memphy seriously.

“What happened to everyone living here?”

Memphy's smile disappeared.

“Some escaped.”

“And the rest?”

“I don't know.”

Leafily lowered her head.

Tulip looked angry.

Vonn stared toward the region.

“We can't leave it like this.”

Vonne nodded.

“No.”

Sparkyle sighed.

“I knew you were going to say that.”

Vonne looked at him.

“You don't have to come.”

Sparkyle immediately looked offended.

“What?”

“You heard me.”

“Absolutely not.”

“You just said you don't like the mission.”

“I don't like the mission.”

“Then—”

“I never said I wasn't coming.”

Vonn laughed.

“That's Sparkyle.”

Leafily smiled.

“Of course he's coming.”

Tulip nodded.

“We all are.”

Memphy looked at the five of them.

“You really mean it?”

Vonne answered first.

“Yes.”

Vonn nodded.

“Absolutely.”

Sparkyle raised his hand.

“Unfortunately, yes.”

Leafily laughed.

“Definitely.”

Tulip smiled.

“We’ll help.”

Memphy looked relieved.

“Thank you.”

Vonne stepped forward.

“Tell us where to start.”

Memphy pointed toward the horizon.

“There's a shelter not far from here.”

“Yours?” Vonn asked.

“Yes.”

“We can plan there.”

“Exactly.”

Sparkyle stretched his arms.

“Finally. Somewhere to sit.”

Tulip laughed.

“You're impossible.”

“I know.”

The group began walking.

Memphy led them toward her shelter.

Vonne walked beside her.

“So how long have you been fighting Restate JR?”

“Long enough.”

“That's not an answer.”

Memphy smiled.

“I've been trying to understand what he's doing.”

Vonn joined the conversation.

“And?”

“He isn't simply trying to conquer the region.”

Vonne looked at her.

“Then what does he want?”

Memphy hesitated.

“He wants to prove something.”

“What?”

“That he can do what his father couldn't.”

Vonne's expression became serious.

“Continue his legacy.”

“Yes.”

Leafily walked closer.

“Does he care about the people here?”

Memphy shook her head.

“No.”

Tulip frowned.

“Then we definitely have to stop him.”

Sparkyle pointed ahead.

“Is that the shelter?”

Memphy nodded.

“Yes.”

The shelter wasn't enormous.

But it was well protected.

There were walls around it, several entrances, and enough space inside for a small group.

Sparkyle smiled.

“Finally.”

He ran toward it.

Vonne laughed.

“Wait!”

Sparkyle shouted back,

“I'm checking whether there's food!”

Vonn shook his head.

“He's unbelievable.”

Leafily smiled.

“That's Sparkyle.”

The group entered the shelter.

Memphy closed the door behind them.

For the first time since they had encountered her,
she looked relaxed.

“Welcome.”

Vonne looked around.

“This place is pretty nice.”

“Thanks.”

Tulip looked around too.

“You've been staying here alone?”

“Mostly.”

“That's lonely.”

Memphy smiled.

“I've gotten used to it.”

Vonne looked at her.

“You don't have to be alone anymore.”

Memphy looked surprised.

Then she smiled.

“Thanks.”

Sparkyle returned carrying something.

“Good news.”

Everyone turned.

“What?”

“I found food.”

Vonne stared at him.

“Where?”

Sparkyle pointed.

“Right there.”

Leafily laughed.

“That was incredibly dramatic.”

“I wanted everyone to appreciate the discovery.”

Vonn shook his head.

“Just eat.”

They all laughed.

For the first time, the situation didn't feel quite as frightening.

They were together.

They had a plan.

And they had Memphy.

But outside the shelter, the region was still under Restate JR's control.

And somewhere far away—

A Bombelo moved through the darkness.

It stopped.

It looked toward Memphy's shelter.

Then another Bombelo appeared beside it.

Neither made a sound.

The danger was getting closer.

The Vonne Pack didn't know it yet.

But their peaceful stay at Memphy's shelter wouldn't last long.

And before they left—

They would receive something that would completely change how they approached the mission.

Three special costumes.

Three new abilities.

And a journey that would eventually lead them straight into Restate JR's territory.

Chapter 2 — Memphy's Shelter

The Vonne Pack had now been staying at Memphy's shelter for a few days.

The shelter had become surprisingly comfortable.

It wasn't huge, but there was enough room for everyone to move around without constantly

bumping into each other. There were shelves along the walls, a few storage areas, some places to sit, and several openings that allowed fresh air to flow through.

More importantly, it was safe.

At least for now.

Vonne was sitting near one of the shelter's entrances, looking outside.

Vonn was lying on the floor nearby.

Sparkyle was examining one of the shelves.

Leafily was sorting through a few objects Memphy had stored there.

And Tulip was sitting quietly with her back against the wall.

Sparkyle suddenly picked something up.

“What is this?”

Memphy looked over.

“Put that down.”

Sparkyle immediately froze.

“Why?”

“Because that's important.”

“What is it?”

“A device.”

“What does it do?”

Memphy sighed.

“It's a navigation device.”

Sparkyle looked at it again.

“Oh.”

He put it back.

Then he picked it up again.

Memphy stared at him.

“Sparkyle.”

“I'm just looking.”

“You're touching it.”

“Looking with my hands.”

Vonn laughed.

“That doesn't make any sense.”

“It makes perfect sense.”

Leafily looked up.

“No, it doesn't.”

Sparkyle carefully returned the device.

“There.”

Memphy nodded.

“Thank you.”

Sparkyle sat down.

“You're welcome.”

There was silence for a few seconds.

Then Sparkyle looked at Vonn.

“So...”

Vonn looked over.

“So what?”

“Are we actually going to do something today?”

Vonn shrugged.

“I don't know.”

Sparkyle looked at Memphy.

“Memphy?”

Memphy was organizing something on a shelf.

“We're not leaving today.”

Sparkyle's eyes widened.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“Because I want you to understand the area before you go.”

Vonn sat up.

“That makes sense.”

Memphy nodded.

“Restate JR's territory is dangerous. If you rush in without understanding the area, you'll get yourselves hurt.”

Sparkyle looked offended.

“We can handle ourselves.”

Memphy smiled.

“I know.”

“Then why—”

“Because knowing you can fight doesn't mean you should fight blindly.”

Sparkyle opened his mouth.

Then closed it.

Vonn laughed.

“She got you.”

Sparkyle crossed his arms.

“Whatever.”

Tulip smiled.

“She's right.”

Sparkyle looked at her.

“Not you too.”

That afternoon, Memphy showed them a rough map of the region.

Everyone gathered around a table.

Memphy placed the map in the middle.

“This is the region.”

She pointed toward one side.

“This is where my shelter is.”

Then she moved her finger farther across the map.

“And this is Restate JR's territory.”

Vonne leaned forward.

“How far?”

“Far enough.”

Vonn pointed at a marked section.

“What's this?”

“An old path.”

“And this?”

“An abandoned settlement.”

Tulip pointed toward another marking.

“And this?”

Memphy paused.

“That area is dangerous.”

Sparkyle immediately leaned closer.

“Why?”

“Because that's where the Flingos usually patrol.”

Sparkyle leaned back.

“Okay. Not going there.”

Vonn pointed toward another area.

“What about this?”

Memphy looked.

“That's an old cave system.”

Leafily looked interested.

“A cave?”

“Yes.”

“Does Restate JR control it?”

“We don't know.”

Vonn looked at her.

“You don't know?”

“No.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“Then maybe that's where we'll go.”

Memphy shook her head.

“Not yet.”

Sparkyle sighed.

“Why does everyone keep saying not yet?”

“Because you keep trying to rush ahead.”

“I do not.”

Everyone looked at him.

Sparkyle looked around.

“...Okay, maybe I do.”

Vonne laughed.

As the day went on, everyone slowly settled into the shelter's routine.

Memphy had become comfortable enough around them that she stopped acting like she needed to constantly explain everything.

Vonne and Vonn often talked about their previous adventures.

Sparkyle constantly made jokes.

Leafily was usually the one trying to keep everyone focused.

And Tulip often listened quietly before adding something that somehow made everyone think.

One evening, the group was sitting together.

Sparkyle looked at Memphy.

“So, Memphy...”

Memphy looked at him.

“Yes?”

“Do you have any friends around here?”

Memphy nodded.

“Some.”

“Who?”

Memphy thought.

“Lyloe.”

Vonn looked up.

“Who's Lyloe?”

“My friend.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“Is Lyloe coming here?”

Memphy shrugged.

“Maybe.”

Tulip looked at Sparkyle.

“I know that expression.”

“What expression?”

“That expression.”

“What expression?”

“The one where you're about to start something.”

Sparkyle smiled innocently.

“I don't know what you're talking about.”

Leafily laughed.

“He definitely is.”

The next morning, someone knocked on the shelter door.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Memphy looked up.

“That's probably Lyloe.”

Sparkyle immediately stood.

“Finally!”

Vonne looked at him.

“Why are you so excited?”

“I want to meet him.”

Memphy opened the door.

A VONS stood outside.

He looked remarkably similar to Memphy.

Vonn stared.

“Whoa.”

Sparkyle stared too.

“Okay...”

Leafily tilted her head.

“They really do look similar.”

Tulip smiled.

“Very similar.”

Memphy smiled.

“Lyloe, come in.”

Lyloe stepped inside.

“Hey, Memphy.”

“Hey.”

Lyloe looked around.

“Who's everyone?”

Memphy pointed around the shelter.

“This is Vonne.”

Vonne waved.

“Hey.”

“Vonn.”

“Hi.”

“Sparkyle.”

Sparkyle waved dramatically.

“Hello.”

Lyloe laughed.

“Okay.”

“Leafily.”

Leafily smiled.

“Nice to meet you.”

“And Tulip.”

Tulip waved.

“Hi.”

Lyloe smiled.

“Nice to meet all of you.”

Sparkyle looked at Memphy.

Then at Lyloe.

Then back at Memphy.

Memphy noticed.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Vonn immediately knew.

“Oh no.”

Leafily covered her face.

“Here we go.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“So...”

Memphy sighed.

“Sparkyle.”

“What?”

“Don't.”

“I haven't even said anything.”

“I know you.”

Sparkyle looked at Lyloe.

“So, you two...”

Memphy's face changed.

“Sparkyle.”

Lyloe looked confused.

“What?”

Sparkyle continued.

“Are you two—”

Memphy's face started turning red.

“Don't.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“A couple?”

Memphy immediately covered her face.

“No!”

Lyloe laughed.

“What?”

“We're just friends!”

Sparkyle laughed.

“Really?”

“Yes!”

Vonn started laughing.

“Sparkyle, leave her alone.”

“But look at her!”

Memphy's face was bright red.

“I'm not blushing!”

Vonn looked at her.

“You're definitely blushing.”

“I am not!”

Tulip laughed.

“You are.”

Leafily nodded.

“Definitely.”

Memphy pointed at everyone.

“You're all terrible!”

Sparkyle laughed.

“I'm just asking questions!”

Lyloe shook his head.

“Sparkyle, you really like causing trouble.”

“It's one of my greatest talents.”

Vonn nodded.

“That might actually be true.”

Memphy finally calmed down.

“Lyloe and I are friends. That's all.”

Sparkyle nodded seriously.

“Understood.”

He paused.

Then smiled.

“Probably.”

Memphy threw a small object at him.

“OW!”

Everyone laughed.

The conversation continued.

Memphy was still slightly embarrassed.

Lyloe sat beside her.

Vonne looked between them.

“So how long have you known each other?”

“Quite a while,” Memphy said.

Lyloe nodded.

“We've known each other for years.”

Sparkyle leaned forward.

“And you've never—”

“Sparkyle.”

“Okay.”

Leafily looked at him.

“Give her a break.”

“Fine.”

Sparkyle sat back.

There was a brief silence.

Then Sparkyle looked at Vonn.

“So, Vonn...”

Vonn looked suspicious.

“What?”

“Why are you staring?”

“I'm not.”

“You are.”

“No.”

“You've been looking at Memphy for like five minutes.”

Vonn looked confused.

“What?”

Memphy looked at him.

“Why were you looking at me?”

Vonn immediately became embarrassed.

“I wasn't.”

Tulip started laughing.

“This is getting worse.”

Leafily shook her head.

“Can we please stop talking about relationships?”

“Thank you!” Memphy said.

Leafily nodded.

“Exactly.”

Sparkyle sighed.

“Fine.”

Lyloe smiled.

“So what were you actually talking about before I came?”

Memphy answered.

“Restate JR.”

Lyloe's expression immediately became serious.

“Oh.”

Vonne noticed.

“You know about him?”

Lyloe nodded.

“Everyone around here does.”

“What do you know?”

Lyloe looked at the map.

“Enough to know that you shouldn't underestimate him.”

Vonn nodded.

“We don't intend to.”

Lyloe looked at them.

“Good.”

Suddenly—

BOOOOOOM!

The shelter shook.

Everyone jumped.

Tulip nearly fell backward.

“What was that?!”

Memphy ran toward the entrance.

“Everyone stay inside!”

Another explosion sounded.

BOOM!

Sparkyle looked outside.

“Bombelo?”

Memphy nodded.

“Yes.”

Vonne stood.

“Where?”

“Nearby.”

Another explosion shook the ground.

Lyloe looked toward the entrance.

“They're getting closer.”

Memphy grabbed something from a shelf.

“We need to move.”

Vonn looked at her.

“Where?”

“Outside first.”

The group rushed out.

Smoke was rising from somewhere nearby.

Sparkyle looked around.

“I don't see anything.”

Then—

A small shape flew over a hill.

Memphy pointed.

“There!”

A Bombelo rushed toward them.

Sparkyle shouted,

“MOVE!”

Everyone scattered.

The Bombelo hit the ground.

BOOM!

Dust exploded into the air.

Vonn rolled away.

Vonne grabbed Tulip's arm and pulled her behind a rock.

Leafily ducked.

Sparkyle jumped sideways.

Memphy flew upward.

Lyloe ran in the opposite direction.

The Bombelo turned.

Sparkyle stared at it.

“Oh, come on.”

Vonn shouted,

“Sparkyle!”

“I KNOW!”

Sparkyle ran.

The Bombelo chased him.

“WHY ME?!”

Vonn laughed despite himself.

“Because you annoyed it!”

“I DIDN'T EVEN TALK TO IT!”

The Bombelo exploded.

Sparkyle jumped out of the way.

BOOM!

He landed on the ground.

“I hate Bombelos.”

Memphy flew back down.

“Everyone okay?”

Vonne nodded.

“I'm fine.”

Vonn nodded.

“Fine.”

Leafily nodded.

“Fine.”

Tulip nodded.

“I'm okay.”

Sparkyle raised his hand.

“I am emotionally damaged.”

Lyloe laughed.

“You're fine.”

“Physically.”

Memphy looked toward the smoking area.

“We can't stay here forever.”

Vonne nodded.

“Then we need equipment.”

Memphy looked at him.

“I was thinking the same thing.”

That evening, Memphy took the group deeper into the shelter.

She opened a storage room.

Inside were several shelves.

Sparkyle's eyes widened.

“Whoa.”

Vonn looked around.

“What is all this?”

“Equipment.”

Memphy walked toward a large storage shelf.

“I've been preparing for a long time.”

Vonne looked at her.

“For Restate JR?”

“Yes.”

Memphy opened a case.

Inside were three strange costumes.

Sparkyle immediately leaned closer.

“What are those?”

Memphy smiled.

“These may help you.”

She picked up the first costume.

It had a lightweight structure and wing-like components.

“This is the **glider costume**.”

Vonn looked interested.

“What does it do?”

“It allows the wearer to glide much farther after gaining speed or launching into the air.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“Okay, that's awesome.”

Memphy put it down.

Then she picked up another.

“This is the **diving costume**.”

Tulip looked at it.

“What does it do?”

“It allows the wearer to stay underwater for extremely long periods and swim much faster.”

Sparkyle's eyes widened.

“So basically unlimited underwater breathing?”

“That's the idea.”

“I'm taking that one.”

Memphy laughed.

“You don't get to choose yet.”

Sparkyle looked disappointed.

Then Memphy picked up the final costume.

“This is the **spiky costume**.”

Vonn examined it.

“What does that do?”

“It provides throwable spikes.”

Sparkyle looked interested again.

“Anything else?”

“Yes.”

Memphy smiled.

“It improves throwing accuracy.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“Okay. Now I definitely want that one.”

Vonn laughed.

“You want everything.”

“I like useful things.”

Leafily looked at the three costumes.

“These could actually help.”

Memphy nodded.

“That's why I kept them.”

Vonne looked at her.

“When do we get them?”

“Tomorrow.”

Sparkyle groaned.

“Tomorrow?”

Memphy nodded.

“We need to make sure you know how to use them first.”

Sparkyle sighed.

“Fine.”

Tulip smiled.

“It's probably better than accidentally launching yourself off a cliff.”

Sparkyle looked at her.

“That happened once.”

Vonn stared.

“Once is enough.”

Later that night, the group sat together again.

The shelter was quiet.

Memphy was sitting near the entrance.

Lyloe was beside her.

Vonne and Vonn were discussing the map.

Leafily was checking the equipment.

Tulip was examining the diving costume.

Sparkyle was staring at the spiky costume.

Vonn looked over.

“You're still looking at it.”

Sparkyle nodded.

“It's cool.”

“You haven't even used it.”

“I know.”

“Then how do you know it's cool?”

“I have intuition.”

Leafily laughed.

“That's not intuition.”

“What is it?”

“Wanting a weapon.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“Maybe.”

Vonne looked toward Memphy.

“Tomorrow we train.”

Memphy nodded.

“Tomorrow.”

“And after that?”

Memphy looked at the map.

“We start moving toward Restate JR's territory.”

The room became quiet.

Vonn looked at the map.

“How long?”

“If everything goes well...”

Memphy paused.

“...not too long.”

Sparkyle looked at everyone.

“And if everything doesn't go well?”

Vonn smiled.

“Then we improvise.”

Sparkyle nodded.

“That's more like us.”

Tulip smiled.

Leafily nodded.

Vonne looked at the group.

“Everyone ready?”

Sparkyle raised his hand.

“No.”

Everyone laughed.

Then Sparkyle smiled.

“Yeah.”

He looked toward the costumes.

“I'm ready.”

Memphy smiled.

“Then tomorrow, your real preparation begins.”

Outside the shelter, the wind moved across the land.

Far away, another Bombelo flew through the darkness.

The Vonne Pack didn't know exactly what waited for them beyond the region.

But now they had a plan.

They had equipment.

They had Memphy.

And they had each other.

Tomorrow, they would begin preparing for the journey toward **Restate JR.**

And this time, they would be ready.

Chapter 3 — The Flight

The next morning, the shelter was unusually noisy.

Not because there was an attack.

Not because another Bombelo had exploded nearby.

Not because Sparkyle had broken something.

It was because Sparkyle had discovered the costumes.

And he had been staring at them for almost an hour.

Three costumes rested on a table inside Memphy's storage room.

One was designed for gliding.

One was covered with sharp, retractable spikes.

And the last one was designed for underwater travel.

Sparkyle stared at all three.

“So...”

Vonn looked over.

“What?”

Sparkyle pointed at the costumes.

“Which one do I get?”

Vonn laughed.

“Why do you assume you're getting one?”

“Because I'm Sparkyle.”

“That doesn't answer anything.”

“It answers everything.”

Leafily shook her head.

“You've been saying that since yesterday.”

Sparkyle looked at her.

“And?”

“And you're still wrong.”

Tulip laughed.

Vonne was standing near the table, looking over the equipment.

Memphy walked into the room.

“Everyone ready?”

Sparkyle immediately pointed toward the costumes.

“We need to settle something first.”

Memphy sighed.

“I know exactly what you're going to ask.”

“Which costume is mine?”

Memphy smiled.

“None of them.”

Sparkyle's face dropped.

“What?!”

Vonn laughed.

Memphy continued,

“These aren't toys. Each costume has a specific purpose.”

Sparkyle crossed his arms.

“Okay. Then who gets them?”

Memphy looked at the three costumes.

“That depends on what we're doing.”

Vonn looked toward the map.

“Flying.”

Memphy nodded.

“Exactly.”

She picked up the glider costume.

“This one is for Vonn.”

Vonn blinked.

“Me?”

“Yes.”

She handed it to him.

Vonn examined it.

“Why me?”

“You're the one who will be launched from the VONS launcher.”

Sparkyle immediately looked at him.

“Lucky.”

Vonn smiled.

“I guess.”

Memphy pointed toward the costume.

“You'll need to activate the glider after the launch. It will slow your descent and allow you to travel a much greater distance.”

Vonn nodded.

“I'll handle it.”

Sparkyle stared at the glider.

“I still think I should have that one.”

Vonn looked at him.

“You can't even stop spinning when you're flying.”

“That was one time.”

“Three times.”

“Details.”

Memphy picked up the second costume.

The spiky one.

She turned toward Leafily.

“This one is yours.”

Leafily looked surprised.

“Mine?”

Memphy nodded.

“You're the most accurate thrower among us.”

Sparkyle looked offended.

“I can throw!”

Leafily looked at him.

“You threw a rock at a tree and missed.”

“It moved.”

“The tree?”

“Yes.”

Vonn laughed.

Leafily took the spiky costume.

“What exactly does it do?”

“It gives you throwable spikes,” Memphis explained. “The costume improves your accuracy and makes the spikes easier to handle.”

Leafily examined one of the attachments.

“These are retractable?”

“Yes.”

“So they're safe when I'm not using them?”

“Correct.”

Leafily nodded.

“Then I'll take it.”

Sparkyle pointed at her.

“Can I try it?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because it's mine.”

Sparkyle sighed.

“Fair.”

Memphy then picked up the final costume.

The underwater costume.

She turned toward Sparkyle.

“This one is yours.”

Sparkyle froze.

“Wait.”

Memphy handed it to him.

“You're giving *me* the underwater costume?”

“Yes.”

Sparkyle looked at it.

Then at Memphy.

Then back at the costume.

“Why?”

“Because we're going to need someone who can explore underwater.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“And I'm the best choice?”

“You're the only one who won't need to worry about breathing normally underwater.”

Sparkyle paused.

“That is actually a very good point.”

Tulip laughed.

“So you're finally useful.”

Sparkyle looked at her.

“Finally?”

Vonne laughed.

Sparkyle held up the costume.

“I'm taking it.”

Memphy nodded.

“Good.”

Sparkyle immediately started examining it.

“How long can I stay underwater?”

“For a very long time.”

“How fast can I swim?”

“Faster than normal.”

“Can I fight underwater?”

“Probably.”

“Can I—”

Memphy raised a hand.

“Sparkyle.”

“What?”

“First learn how to use it.”

Sparkyle sighed.

“Fine.”

Vonne looked at the three of them.

“So it's settled.”

He pointed toward himself.

“Glider.”

Then Leafily.

“Spiky.”

Then Sparkyle.

“Underwater.”

Tulip nodded.

“And the rest of us?”

Memphy answered,

“You won't need special costumes for this part.”

Vonne nodded.

“Okay.”

Vonne looked at Tulip.

“You're staying with us?”

Tulip smiled.

“Obviously.”

Vonne smiled back.

Memphy folded the map.

“Then let's move.”

They packed their supplies.

Vonn secured the glider costume.

Leafily carefully stored the spiky equipment.

Sparkyle proudly carried the underwater costume.

Vonne carried the supplies.

Tulip carried the map.

Memphy led the group.

They left the shelter.

The morning air was cool.

The land ahead looked peaceful.

But everyone knew better.

They were heading toward Restate JR's territory.

And there was no guarantee the journey would remain peaceful.

They walked for several hours.

The terrain slowly changed.

The hills became steeper.

The ground became rougher.

There were signs of previous attacks everywhere.

Burned patches of land.

Broken structures.

Old craters.

Vonne looked around.

“He's been here.”

Memphy nodded.

“Restate JR's forces have moved through this entire region.”

Tulip looked at one of the damaged areas.

“How long ago?”

“Not long.”

Sparkyle looked at the sky.

“So we're being watched.”

Memphy didn't answer immediately.

Then she said,

“Possibly.”

Everyone became more alert.

Vonn adjusted the glider costume.

Leafily checked her equipment.

Sparkyle looked at his underwater costume.

“I'm ready.”

Vonne laughed.

“We haven't even reached the launcher.”

“I can still be ready.”

Eventually, Memphy stopped.

“There.”

Everyone looked ahead.

A massive structure stood across the landscape.

It was the VONS launcher.

It was enormous.

A large launch platform extended from the ground.

Several mechanical components surrounded it.

Vonn stared.

“That's huge.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“Now *that's* a launcher.”

Leafily looked at Vonn.

“You're going to be launched from that?”

Vonn nodded.

“Apparently.”

Tulip looked nervous.

“That's going to hurt.”

Memphy shook her head.

“Not if he follows the instructions.”

Vonn smiled.

“I'll be fine.”

Sparkyle walked toward him.

“Just don't scream.”

Vonn looked at him.

“You screamed during practice.”

“I did not.”

“You absolutely did.”

Leafily laughed.

“I heard you.”

Sparkyle pointed at her.

“You weren't supposed to.”

Memphy brought everyone to the launch platform.

“Listen carefully.”

Everyone stopped joking.

“When the launcher fires, Vonn will be launched approximately fifteen kilometers.”

Vonn nodded.

Memphy continued.

“Do not try to activate the glider immediately.”

Vonn listened carefully.

“You need to gain enough distance first.”

“How long?”

“Until I give you the signal.”

Vonn nodded.

“And then?”

“Activate the glider.”

Memphy looked at the others.

“Everyone else will follow separately.”

Leafily nodded.

Sparkyle raised his hand.

“What am I doing?”

“You're not using the glider.”

“I know.”

“You'll remain with the ground team.”

Sparkyle frowned.

“What?”

Memphy smiled.

“Until we reach the underwater section.”

Sparkyle's face immediately brightened.

“Oh.”

He looked down at his costume.

“Then this is going to be useful.”

“Very.”

They began practicing.

Vonn was first.

He stepped onto the launcher.

Sparkyle shouted,

“GOOD LUCK!”

Vonn turned.

“Thanks.”

Sparkyle shouted again,

“DON'T DIE!”

Vonn stared at him.

“Why would you say that?!”

“Motivation!”

Leafily laughed.

Memphy shook her head.

“Vonn, focus.”

Vonn took a breath.

“Ready.”

The launcher began charging.

WHIRRRRRRRR—

Vonn braced himself.

Memphy shouted,

“NOW!”

BOOOOOOM!

Vonn shot forward.

“WHOA!”

He disappeared across the horizon.

Everyone stared.

Tulip blinked.

“That was fast.”

Sparkyle nodded.

“Very.”

Memphy watched carefully.

Then she smiled.

“He's doing it.”

Far away, Vonn activated the glider.

The wings opened.

His descent slowed.

He began gliding smoothly.

Vonne smiled.

“Perfect.”

The group continued toward the next launch point.

Vonn eventually landed far ahead.

He waited for the others.

When they finally caught up, Sparkyle immediately walked toward him.

“You survived.”

Vonn stared.

“Thanks?”

“You're welcome.”

Vonn shook his head.

Leafily approached.

“How was it?”

“Fast.”

“Scary?”

“A little.”

Sparkyle laughed.

“You screamed.”

“I did not.”

“You definitely did.”

Vonn pointed at him.

“You screamed first.”

“That's unrelated.”

Leafily laughed.

“Both of you are ridiculous.”

They continued.

Eventually, they reached a large stretch of water.

Sparkyle looked at it.

Then looked at Memphy.

Then looked at his underwater costume.

His eyes widened.

“This is why I got it.”

Memphy nodded.

“Exactly.”

Sparkyle immediately began putting it on.

Vonn looked at him.

“You sure?”

Sparkyle nodded.

“Absolutely.”

Leafily checked her spiky costume.

Vonne looked across the water.

Tulip stood beside Memphy.

Memphy pointed toward the far side.

“There.”

Sparkyle looked.

“What?”

“The route continues underwater.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“Finally.”

He jumped into the water.

SPLASH!

Vonn laughed.

“He didn't even wait.”

Leafily shook her head.

“He's impossible.”

Memphy smiled.

“He's also useful.”

Sparkyle disappeared beneath the surface.

The underwater costume activated.

He swam through the water quickly.

He looked around.

The underwater world was darker than expected.

Rock formations surrounded him.

Strange plants moved with the current.

He continued forward.

Then he spotted something.

A large structure beneath the water.

Sparkyle stopped.

“What is that?”

He swam closer.

It looked like an old passage.

He looked back toward the surface.

Then continued.

Above the water, Vonn waited.

“What's taking him so long?”

Memphy looked at the water.

“He'll come back.”

Leafily nodded.

“He's probably exploring.”

Vonne laughed.

“Probably.”

A few moments later—

SPLASH!

Sparkyle surfaced.

“I found something!”

Everyone turned.

“What?” Vonn asked.

“There's a passage underwater.”

Memphy's expression became serious.

“Where?”

Sparkyle pointed.

“Over there.”

Memphy looked toward the location.

“That could be important.”

Sparkyle grinned.

“I knew this costume would be useful.”

Leafily smiled.

“Good job.”

Sparkyle looked proud.

“Thank you.”

They moved toward the underwater passage.

But before they could enter—

A sharp sound cut through the air.

WHOOSH!

A projectile flew past.

Memphy shouted,

“DOWN!”

Everyone ducked.

Another projectile flew.

Leafily immediately pulled out one of her spikes.

“Restate JR's forces.”

Vonn looked toward the horizon.

“I see them!”

Several enemy units were approaching.

Sparkyle looked at the water.

“We're being attacked.”

Vonne nodded.

“Then we move.”

Memphy shouted,

“Keep moving toward the cave!”

They began running.

Leafily threw a spike.

THUNK!

It struck an approaching enemy's equipment.

“Nice!” Sparkyle shouted.

Leafily smiled.

“Thanks.”

Vonn ran beside them.

“Keep going!”

They reached the edge of the rocky area.

Then they saw it.

A huge cave entrance.

Memphy stopped.

“This is it.”

Vonn looked at the cave.

“The cave?”

Memphy nodded.

“Yes.”

Sparkyle looked toward the entrance.

“So this is where Restate JR's forces are coming from?”

“We don't know.”

Vonne stepped forward.

“Then we'll find out.”

The group entered the cave.

Vonn kept his glider secured.

Leafily kept her spikes ready.

Sparkyle kept his underwater costume activated.

Tulip stayed close to Memphy.

The cave became darker with every step.

Water dripped from the ceiling.

Their footsteps echoed.

Nobody spoke for several seconds.

Then Sparkyle whispered,

“Guys?”

Vonn whispered back.

“What?”

“I really hope there's no Bombelo in here.”

Leafily laughed quietly.

“Why?”

“Because I don't want to fight a Bombelo in a cave.”

Vonn smiled.

“Fair.”

Memphy stopped.

Everyone stopped with her.

She looked deeper into the cave.

“There.”

A faint glow could be seen in the distance.

Vonn looked at it.

“What is that?”

Memphy shook her head.

“I don't know.”

Leafily tightened her grip on the spikes.

Sparkyle looked toward the water running along the cave floor.

Vonne took a step forward.

“Let's find out.”

The group moved deeper into the cave.

Behind them, the entrance slowly disappeared into darkness.

Ahead, the strange glow grew brighter.

And somewhere beyond it...

something was waiting.

The cave grew darker as the Vonne Pack moved deeper inside.

Their footsteps echoed against the stone walls.

Drip.

Drip.

Drip.

Every few seconds, water fell from the ceiling and splashed onto the cave floor.

Vonn walked near the front.

Vonne stayed beside him.

Leafily followed close behind, keeping her spiky costume ready.

Sparkyle was slightly farther back, occasionally looking at the water flowing along the side of the cave.

Tulip stayed near Memphy.

Memphy's damaged wing still bothered her, but she refused to slow everyone down.

Sparkyle suddenly stopped.

“Guys.”

Everyone stopped.

Vonn turned.

“What?”

Sparkyle pointed toward the wall.

“Look.”

Everyone looked.

There were strange markings carved into the stone.

They looked almost like symbols.

Tulip walked closer.

“What are those?”

Memphy examined them.

“I’ve never seen those before.”

Vonn touched one of the markings.

It glowed faintly.

He immediately pulled his hand away.

“Okay.”

Sparkyle stared at it.

“That was definitely not normal.”

Leafily nodded.

“Definitely not.”

Vonne looked deeper into the cave.

“Keep moving.”

They continued.

The cave became narrower.

Soon, they reached a fork.

Three tunnels stretched in different directions.

Vonn looked at them.

“Which one?”

Memphy shook her head.

“I don't know.”

Sparkyle pointed toward the middle tunnel.

“That one.”

Vonn looked at him.

“Why?”

“It looks cooler.”

“That is not a reason.”

“It is to me.”

Tulip laughed.

“We're not letting Sparkyle choose based on how cool a tunnel looks.”

Sparkyle crossed his arms.

“Fine.”

Vonn examined the ground.

There were faint marks in the dust.

“Someone's been through here.”

Memphy crouched beside him.

“These footprints are old.”

“How old?”

“Hard to tell.”

Leafily pointed toward the left tunnel.

“There are more markings there.”

Vonn looked.

“Then that's our route.”

Everyone followed.

The tunnel eventually opened into a massive chamber.

Everyone stopped.

The room was enormous.

The ceiling disappeared into darkness.

There were stone platforms everywhere, separated by deep gaps.

Some platforms floated slightly above the ground.

Others were connected by narrow stone bridges.

At the far end stood a huge stone door.

But the strangest thing was the light.

Three glowing objects floated in the middle of the chamber.

Three **orbs**.

One was blue.

One was golden.

One was white.

They floated silently above three stone pedestals.

Sparkyle stared.

“Whoa.”

Tulip whispered,

“What are those?”

Vonn slowly walked forward.

“I don't know.”

Memphy looked at them carefully.

“They weren't mentioned on any map.”

Leafily looked at the three orbs.

“They look powerful.”

Vonne nodded.

“Very.”

Sparkyle stepped closer.

The blue orb suddenly pulsed.

WHOOM.

A wave of blue light spread across the chamber.

Everyone stepped backward.

“What was that?” Tulip asked.

Vonn looked around.

Nothing seemed to have changed.

Then the golden orb pulsed.

WHOOM.

This time, the stone beneath their feet vibrated.

Sparkyle looked down.

“Okay...”

Then the white orb pulsed.

The entire cave went silent.

Vonn stared at the three orbs.

“I think they're connected to this place.”

Memphy nodded.

“Probably.”

Vonne looked at the stone door.

“Maybe they're keys.”

Leafily shook her head.

“Maybe.”

Sparkyle walked toward the blue orb.

Vonn grabbed his shoulder.

“Don't.”

Sparkyle stopped.

“Why?”

“We don't know what it does.”

Sparkyle looked at the orb.

“That's exactly why I want to touch it.”

Vonn sighed.

“Of course.”

Vonn walked around the chamber.

He examined the walls.

There were more symbols.

Some were similar to the markings they had seen earlier.

Others showed strange creatures.

One showed what looked like a large explosion.

Another showed a region divided into several sections.

Leafily came over.

“What did you find?”

Vonn pointed.

“Look at this.”

Leafily stared.

The drawing showed a large orb in the center.

Around it were several areas of land.

She frowned.

“Wait.”

“What?”

“These aren't just pictures.”

She traced the markings with her finger.

“They look like a map.”

Vonn looked again.

“You're right.”

Vonne and Memphy came over.

“What is it?” Vonne asked.

Leafily pointed at the map.

“I think these orbs control something outside the cave.”

Memphy looked closely.

“What makes you think that?”

“Look.”

She pointed at three sections of the map.

“There are three areas.”

Vonn looked at the three orbs.

“And three orbs.”

Vonne's eyes widened.

“So each orb corresponds to one part of the region?”

“Maybe.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“That means they're important.”

Memphy nodded.

“Very.”

Vonn looked at the stone door.

“And if Restate JR is using this cave...”

Vonne finished the thought.

“He may be using these orbs to control the region.”

Everyone became quiet.

Sparkyle looked at the blue orb.

“Then we take them.”

Memphy looked at him.

“We don't know what happens if we do.”

Vonn nodded.

“But leaving them here could be worse.”

Vonne looked at the map.

“We need to understand what they do first.”

Suddenly—

CLANG!

Something hit the stone behind them.

Everyone spun around.

A creature stood on one of the platforms.

It was a guardian.

It had stone-like armor covering its body.

Its eyes glowed.

Sparkyle whispered,

“Oh.”

The guardian roared.

ROOOOOAR!

Vonne shouted,

“MOVE!”

The guardian charged.

Vonn jumped backward.

Leafily pulled out a spike.

She threw it.

THUNK!

The spike hit the guardian's shoulder.

It barely reacted.

Leafily's eyes widened.

“That's not good.”

Sparkyle ran forward.

“I'll distract it!”

“Sparkyle!” Vonn shouted.

Too late.

Sparkyle dashed across the platform.

The guardian followed.

Sparkyle dodged left.

The guardian swung.

Sparkyle ducked.

The stone fist smashed into the floor.

BOOM!

Sparkyle grinned.

“You missed!”

The guardian roared again.

Sparkyle ran toward the blue orb.

Vonn realized what he was doing.

“Sparkyle, wait!”

Sparkyle jumped onto the pedestal.

He grabbed the blue orb.

The entire chamber flashed.

WHOOM!

The guardian froze.

Sparkyle stared at the orb in his hands.

“Uh...”

The guardian suddenly turned toward him.

Sparkyle's smile disappeared.

“Oh no.”

The guardian charged.

Sparkyle ran.

“GUYS!”

Vonn rushed forward.

Vonne grabbed Sparkyle's arm.

“COME ON!”

They sprinted across the chamber.

The guardian chased them.

Leafily threw another spike.

This time it struck the ground directly in front of the guardian.

The creature stopped for a fraction of a second.

Vonn shouted,

“Now!”

Sparkyle threw the orb toward Vonn.

Vonn caught it.

The blue light grew brighter.

The chamber shook.

Then—

Silence.

The guardian stopped moving.

Its eyes dimmed.

It slowly lowered its arms.

Everyone stared.

Sparkyle blinked.

“Did we win?”

Memphy looked at the orb.

“I think...”

She paused.

“...the guardian was protecting the orb.”

Vonn looked toward the stone door.

Something had changed.

A section of the door had turned blue.

Tulip gasped.

“The door!”

Vonne looked.

A blue symbol was glowing on it.

Leafily smiled.

“So the orb really is a key.”

Vonn held the blue orb carefully.

Suddenly, a faint image appeared above it.

A map.

The group gathered around.

The map showed the region.

One large section was glowing blue.

Vonne looked at it.

“That part...”

Memphy nodded.

“I know it.”

“What happens there?”

Memphy looked surprised.

“I don't know.”

The blue glow expanded.

Then the image changed.

They saw a section of land covered in dark markings.

The markings began disappearing.

Sparkyle stared.

“It's removing something.”

Leafily nodded.

“Maybe Restate JR's control.”

Vonn looked at Memphy.

“So if we take all three...”

“We may free the entire region,” Memphy said.

Everyone became silent.

Vonne looked at the remaining two orbs.

“Then we need them.”

The second orb was harder to reach.

The golden orb floated above a platform separated from the others by a huge gap.

There was no bridge.

Vonn looked down.

“That's too far to jump.”

Sparkyle looked at Vonn.

“Use the glider.”

Vonn looked at him.

“Inside a cave?”

Sparkyle shrugged.

“Worth trying.”

Vonn looked at the ceiling.

It was high enough.

“Maybe.”

He put on the glider.

Memphy looked concerned.

“Be careful.”

Vonn nodded.

He ran toward the edge.

Jumped.

And activated the glider.

The costume opened.

Vonn sailed across the gap.

“YES!”

He landed on the opposite platform.

Sparkyle shouted,

“Nice!”

Vonn smiled.

“Easy.”

Then the platform shook.

Vonn froze.

“Oh.”

A second guardian rose from the stone.

This one was faster.

Vonn immediately ran.

The guardian chased him.

Vonn jumped over a stone pillar.

The guardian smashed through it.

Vonn looked toward the golden orb.

“There!”

He ran toward it.

The guardian was getting closer.

Vonn jumped onto the pedestal.

He grabbed the orb.

WHOOM!

Golden light exploded across the chamber.

The guardian stopped.

Vonn stared.

“Please work...”

The creature slowly lowered its head.

Then it vanished into dust.

Vonn exhaled.

“Okay.”

He looked across the gap.

“Guys!”

Sparkyle shouted,

“Throw it!”

Vonn tossed the orb.

Vonne caught it.

The golden symbol appeared on the stone door.

Another section of the region lit up.

Memphy stared at the map.

“It's working.”

The group returned to the central chamber.

Only one orb remained.

The white one.

But something was different.

The third orb wasn't simply floating above a normal pedestal.

It was behind another doorway.

And that doorway was enormous.

Vonne looked at it.

“That's probably the final guardian.”

Memphy nodded.

“I think so.”

Sparkyle looked at the doorway.

“How strong?”

Memphy stared at the markings.

“Stronger.”

“Stronger than the other guardians?”

“Yes.”

“How much stronger?”

Memphy looked at him.

“Enough that you shouldn't fight it alone.”

Sparkyle smiled.

“Good thing I'm not alone.”

Vonn stepped forward.

“Exactly.”

Leafily prepared another spike.

Tulip moved beside Memphy.

Vonne looked toward the door.

“Then let's open it.”

They pushed the stone door.

Nothing happened.

Vonn looked at the two orbs.

He placed the blue orb into the blue slot.

Then Vonne placed the golden orb into the golden slot.

The door began glowing.

RUMBLE...

The entire chamber shook.

The door slowly opened.

A deep growl came from inside.

Everyone froze.

Sparkyle whispered,

“That's not a guardian.”

Vonn looked into the darkness.

Something moved.

Two enormous eyes appeared.

Tulip stepped backward.

“What is that?”

The creature stepped forward.

It was enormous.

Its body was covered in thick armor.

Its claws scraped across the stone.

It looked stronger than any guardian they had fought so far.

Memphy stared.

“That...”

Vonne swallowed.

“What?”

Memphy whispered,

“That's the guardian of the final orb.”

The creature roared.

The sound shook the entire cave.

ROOOOOOOOOOAR!

Sparkyle clenched his fists.

Vonn activated his glider.

Leafily raised her spikes.

Vonne prepared himself.

Tulip moved beside Memphy.

And the enormous beast charged.

The guardian charged.

The enormous creature slammed one claw into the stone floor.

BOOOOOOM!

The entire chamber shook.

Vonn jumped backward.

“MOVE!”

Everyone scattered.

Vonne pulled Tulip away from the center.

Leafily rolled across the floor and immediately reached for another spike.

Sparkyle ran toward the side of the chamber.

Memphy tried to move with them, but her damaged wing made her slower.

The guardian turned toward her.

Vonn saw it.

“MEMPHY!”

The creature raised its claw.

Vonn launched himself forward.

He slammed into the guardian's arm.

The impact knocked him backward.

He hit the floor hard.

“VONN!”

Vonne ran toward him.

“I'm okay!”

The guardian turned again.

This time it charged directly at the group.

Leafily threw a spike.

THUNK!

The spike struck its armor.

Nothing.

She stared.

“That's not working!”

Sparkyle shouted,

“Try the eyes!”

Leafily looked at him.

“That's your plan?!”

“It usually works!”

“Usually?!”

The guardian swung.

Everyone ducked.

Its claw smashed into the wall.

Stone exploded everywhere.

Tulip covered her face.

“WE NEED A BETTER PLAN!”

Vonne looked around the chamber.

Then he noticed something.

The guardian wasn't attacking randomly.

It was protecting the white orb.

Every time someone moved toward the orb, it immediately changed direction.

Vonne shouted,

“It's protecting the orb!”

Vonn looked at him.

“So?”

“So we don't have to beat it first!”

Leafily understood.

“We distract it!”

Vonne nodded.

“Exactly!”

Sparkyle grinned.

“I volunteer!”

Vonn stared at him.

“You always volunteer for the dangerous part.”

“I'm very consistent.”

Sparkyle ran.

The guardian immediately turned toward him.

“HEY, ROCK FACE!”

The guardian roared.

Sparkyle ran across the chamber.

“COME ON!”

The guardian chased him.

Sparkyle ducked beneath a claw.

“Missed!”

The guardian swung again.

Sparkyle jumped.

“Still missed!”

Vonn looked toward the orb.

“Now!”

Leafily sprinted toward the pedestal.

Vonne followed.

Tulip stayed with Memphy.

Vonn flew upward with his glider and circled around the guardian.

The creature became confused.

Sparkyle shouted,

“KEEP LOOKING AT ME!”

Vonn shouted,

“SPARKYLE, MOVE!”

Sparkyle looked behind him.

The guardian was directly there.

“Oh.”

He ran.

“EVERYONE MOVE!”

Leafily reached the pedestal.

She grabbed the white orb.

The entire chamber flashed.

WHOOOOOM!

The guardian stopped.

Everything became silent.

Leafily stared at the orb.

“I got it.”

Vonne smiled.

“We did it.”

Then the guardian slowly turned.

Its eyes began glowing again.

Sparkyle stared.

“Uh...”

Vonn looked at it.

“Why is it still moving?”

Memphy's expression changed.

“The guardian isn't connected to the orb.”

“What?”

“It was guarding it.”

Vonn's smile disappeared.

“So...”

Memphy nodded.

“Taking the orb didn't defeat it.”

The creature roared.

ROOOOOOOAR!

Sparkyle sighed.

“Of course.”

The guardian charged again.

This time, everyone attacked together.

Vonn flew around it, forcing it to turn.

Leafily threw spikes at the joints in its armor.

Vonne attacked from the ground.

Tulip helped Memphy move out of the way
whenever the guardian got close.

Sparkyle used the underwater costume's equipment
to move quickly through a stream running across
the chamber, appearing from different directions.

The guardian became increasingly frustrated.

It slammed its claw down.

Vonne jumped.

The claw missed him by inches.

Vonn shouted,

“NOW!”

Leafily threw a spike.

THUNK!

It struck a weak point in the guardian's armor.

The creature stumbled.

Sparkyle shouted,

“AGAIN!”

Leafily threw another.

THUNK!

The guardian roared.

Vonne flew directly toward it.

He kicked the side of its head.

The creature staggered.

Vonne landed.

“It's working!”

Vonn smiled.

“Keep going!”

They attacked again.

And again.

And again.

Finally—

CRACK!

A large section of the guardian's armor broke.

The creature stumbled backward.

The entire chamber shook.

The guardian roared one final time.

Then its body began turning into stone.

Its claws froze.

Its armor hardened.

Its eyes faded.

And slowly—

It collapsed.

BOOOOM.

Dust filled the chamber.

Everyone stood still.

Sparkyle coughed.

“Did we...”

Vonne waved the dust away.

“Yeah.”

Leafily lowered her spikes.

“We did.”

Vonne looked at the white orb.

“Then that's all three.”

Memphy looked at the three orbs.

“Put them together.”

Leafily brought the white orb over.

Vonn placed the blue orb beside it.

Vonne placed the golden orb next to them.

The three orbs floated upward.

Blue.

Gold.

White.

They began rotating around each other.

The chamber filled with light.

A deep sound echoed through the cave.

WHOOM.

Then—

A map appeared above them.

But this time, it wasn't just a map.

It showed the entire region.

Three different areas were glowing.

Then one by one, the dark markings covering them disappeared.

Vonn stared.

“It's working.”

Memphy whispered,

“The region...”

Tulip smiled.

“It's being freed.”

Sparkyle looked amazed.

“So Restate JR's control really was connected to these.”

Memphy nodded.

“Yes.”

Vonne looked at the map.

“Then we've already done something important.”

Vonn smiled.

“And we haven't even reached Restate JR yet.”

Nobody answered.

Because that sentence made everyone realize something.

If Restate JR had been powerful enough to control the region through those orbs...

then he wasn't going to be happy that the Vonne Pack had destroyed them.

The three orbs slowly descended.

They landed on the ground.

The cave suddenly became quiet.

The strange symbols on the walls began glowing.

Then a sound echoed from somewhere deeper.

BOOM.

Everyone looked toward the tunnel.

Another sound.

BOOM.

Sparkyle frowned.

“That isn't the cave collapsing.”

Vonne nodded.

“No.”

Memphy looked frightened.

“What?”

Vonn looked at her.

“What is it?”

Memphy didn't answer.

Then a voice echoed through the cave.

“You really thought you could destroy my orbs?”

Everyone froze.

Sparkyle whispered,

“Who was that?”

The voice came again.

“You have caused quite a problem.”

Vonne's expression hardened.

“Restate JR.”

Memphy nodded.

“That voice...”

Another sound.

Footsteps.

Slow.

Heavy.

Getting closer.

THUD.

THUD.

THUD.

Vonn clenched his fists.

“He's here.”

Leafily moved closer to Vonn.

Tulip stood beside Memphy.

Sparkyle looked around.

“Where?”

The footsteps stopped.

Then a figure appeared at the far end of the tunnel.

Everyone stared.

Restate JR.

He stood in the darkness.

He looked at the destroyed orb chamber.

Then at the three orbs.

Then at the Vonne Pack.

His expression changed.

“You.”

Vonne stepped forward.

“Restate JR.”

Restate JR smiled.

“So you've come after all.”

Vonn stepped beside Vonne.

“We came to stop you.”

Restate JR laughed.

“Stop me?”

He looked around.

“You've destroyed three objects that took me years to obtain.”

Sparkyle crossed his arms.

“Sounds like your problem.”

Restate JR's smile disappeared.

“You think this is funny?”

Sparkyle shrugged.

“A little.”

Vonne looked at him.

“Maybe don't provoke him.”

“Too late.”

Restate JR looked at the group.

“I know all of you.”

Leafily frowned.

“You do?”

“Yes.”

He looked at Vonn.

“I know your strength.”

Then Vonne.

“I know your history.”

Then Sparkyle.

“I know what you are capable of.”

Then Leafily.

“And I know what you protect.”

Finally, his eyes moved toward Memphy.

“And you...”

Memphy froze.

“You're the one who brought them here.”

Restate JR smiled.

“You made a mistake.”

Memphy stepped forward.

“No.”

Restate JR raised an eyebrow.

“No?”

Memphy looked directly at him.

“I made the right choice.”

Restate JR laughed.

“Then let's see.”

He raised his hand.

The cave began shaking.

Stone fell from the ceiling.

Vonne shouted,

“Everyone out!”

The group ran.

Restate JR followed.

They raced through the tunnels.

Vonn used his glider to jump across gaps.

Leafily used spikes to knock falling rocks away.

Sparkyle used the water channels to move rapidly.

Tulip stayed beside Memphy.

Vonne led everyone toward the cave entrance.

Behind them, Restate JR continued walking.

He wasn't even running.

He didn't need to.

He knew they couldn't escape forever.

They finally burst out of the cave.

The sunlight hit their eyes.

Everyone stopped.

Vonn looked around.

The land looked different.

The dark markings were gone.

Parts of the region were already beginning to recover.

Tulip smiled.

“We did it.”

Memphy looked around.

“The region is free.”

Vonne looked at her.

“Not yet.”

Memphy turned.

Vonne pointed behind them.

Restate JR was walking out of the cave.

He stepped into the sunlight.

He looked at the group.

Then at the restored land.

His expression became cold.

“You have no idea what you've done.”

Vonn stepped forward.

“We know exactly what we've done.”

Restate JR smiled.

“Then you know what comes next.”

Vonn clenched his fists.

“Yes.”

Restate JR raised his arm.

A strange energy began forming around him.

The air became hot.

Sparkyle stepped forward.

“Oh boy.”

Leafily tightened her grip.

Tulip moved beside Memphy.

Vonne looked at Vonn.

“You ready?”

Vonn nodded.

“Always.”

Restate JR suddenly disappeared.

BOOM!

He appeared directly in front of Vonn.

Vonn barely dodged.

Restate JR swung.

Vonn blocked.

The impact sent him sliding backward.

Vonne shouted,

“VONN!”

Vonn stood.

“I'm fine!”

Restate JR smiled.

“Good.”

He raised his hand.

“Because I'm not finished.”

A massive blast of energy shot toward them.

Everyone scattered.

The final battle had begun.

Vonn charged.

Restate JR blocked.

Vonn struck again.

Restate JR dodged.

Vonne attacked from the side.

Restate JR blocked him too.

Sparkyle rushed forward.

Restate JR knocked him backward.

Leafily threw three spikes.

Restate JR dodged all three.

Tulip tried to help Sparkyle back up.

Memphy shouted,

“Stay back!”

Tulip shook her head.

“No!”

Memphy looked at her.

“This is too dangerous!”

Tulip answered,

“So is letting them fight alone!”

Memphy smiled slightly.

“Then stay close.”

They moved forward.

The fight became faster.

Vonn and Vonne attacked together.

Sparkyle moved around Restate JR.

Leafily threw spikes whenever she saw an opening.

Tulip helped the group stay together.

Memphy tried to support them despite her damaged wing.

But Restate JR was stronger than they expected.

Much stronger.

He struck Vonn.

Vonn fell.

Vonne rushed toward him.

Restate JR intercepted him.

The two collided.

BOOM!

Vonne was thrown backward.

Sparkyle shouted,

“VONNE!”

Vonne pushed himself up.

“I’m okay.”

Restate JR smiled.

“You’re all strong.”

He raised his hand.

“But you’re still not strong enough.”

Then he attacked again.

The Vonne Pack fought back.

But the battle was only beginning.

And nobody knew that before it ended—

Vonn would permanently lose one mystic...

and gain another.

Chapter 5 — Restate JR

The cave was silent.

Not peaceful.

Not safe.

Silent.

The kind of silence that made every tiny sound feel enormous.

A small piece of rock rolled down the cave wall.

Tick.

It bounced once.

Tick.

Then stopped.

Vonn stood at the front of the group, staring into the darkness.

Sparkyle stood beside him.

Leafily was a little behind them.

Vonne and Tulip stood together near the cave entrance, both watching the darkness.

Memphy's damaged left wing was folded tightly against her side.

And then—

A pair of eyes appeared.

Two glowing eyes.

Restate JR stepped out of the darkness.

His footsteps echoed through the cave.

THUD.

THUD.

THUD.

He stopped.

He looked at the five members of Vonne Pack.

Then he looked at Memphy.

Then at the destroyed orbs.

His expression changed.

"Three orbs."

Nobody answered.

Restate JR slowly looked around the cave.

"You actually did it."

Vonn tightened his fists.

"Yep."

Restate JR smiled.

"Do you know what those orbs represented?"

Sparkyle tilted his head.

"Expensive decorations?"

Tulip whispered, "Sparkyle..."

"What?"

"You really need to stop talking to villains."

"I was making conversation."

Restate JR ignored him.

"The orbs were the final locks."

Vonne frowned.

"Locks?"

"Locks that protected this region from me."

Memphy's eyes narrowed.

"And now they're gone."

"Exactly."

Restate JR raised one hand.

A dark pulse moved through the cave.

The ground shook.

BOOOOM.

Dust fell from the ceiling.

Leafily jumped.

"Okay! Definitely not good!"

Vonne looked at Restate JR.

"So you needed us to destroy them?"

Restate JR laughed.

"You were useful."

Vonn stepped forward.

"You used us."

"Of course."

Vonn's fists tightened.

Restate JR continued.

"The guardians were keeping me from reaching the center of the region. You defeated them. You destroyed the orbs. You removed the barriers."

Sparkyle stared at him.

"So..."

He pointed at Restate JR.

"You've basically been waiting for us to do your homework."

Restate JR stared at him.

Sparkyle slowly lowered his hand.

"That sounded funnier in my head."

Vonne stepped forward.

"You don't get this region."

Restate JR smiled.

"That is no longer your decision."

Memphy moved forward despite her injured wing.

"Restate JR."

He looked at her.

"You."

Memphy stared directly into his eyes.

"You've already taken enough."

Restate JR's expression became colder.

"I haven't taken anything."

"You took the region."

"I claimed it."

"You attacked everyone who resisted."

"I removed obstacles."

"You hurt people."

"They resisted."

"You destroyed homes."

"They were in my way."

Memphy's wing trembled.

"And now you're going to destroy the rest."

Restate JR shrugged.

"That depends."

"On what?"

"On whether you all decide to resist."

Vonn stepped forward.

"We do."

Restate JR looked at him.

"All of you?"

Vonne nodded.

"All of us."

Tulip stepped beside her.

"Yep."

Leafily raised her fists.

"Absolutely."

Sparkyle's eyes lit up.

"Definitely."

Vonn stepped forward last.

"Every single one."

Restate JR smiled.

"Then let's begin."

The cave exploded with energy.

Restate JR slammed both hands into the ground.

A shockwave blasted outward.

"DOWN!"

Vonne dropped.

Tulip jumped.

Leafily ducked.

Sparkyle folded his arms around himself.

Vonn jumped over the shockwave.

The blast struck the cave walls.

BOOOOM!

Rock cracked.

"He's strong!" Leafily shouted.

Vonn landed.

"I noticed!"

Restate JR moved.

He was suddenly right in front of Vonn.

Vonn barely raised his arms before—

BAM!

Vonn was thrown backward.

He hit the cave floor.

"VONN!"

Leafily ran toward him.

"I'm okay!"

Vonn pushed himself up.

Restate JR was already coming.

Sparkyle stepped between them.

"Hey!"

Restate JR punched.

Sparkyle blocked.

The impact sent a shockwave through the cave.

Sparkyle slid backward.

His feet carved two lines into the stone.

He looked at his arms.

"Okay."

He looked at Restate JR.

"That hurt."

Restate JR attacked again.

Sparkyle ducked.

Vonne rushed in from the side.

Tulip threw a rock.

It struck Restate JR's shoulder.

He turned.

"Really?"

Tulip shrugged.

"It was nearby."

Vonne attacked.

Restate JR blocked.

Vonn attacked from behind.

Restate JR blocked again.

Leafily jumped over him.

Vonne kicked.

Sparkyle struck.

Tulip moved around the side.

For a moment, the five worked together perfectly.

Restate JR was forced backward.

One step.

Two.

Three.

Then he smiled.

"Better."

Vonn frowned.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"You've improved."

Restate JR suddenly disappeared.

Vonne's eyes widened.

"Where—"

CRASH!

Restate JR appeared behind Leafily.

He struck.

Leafily flew across the cave.

"LEAFILY!"

Vonn's expression changed instantly.

He rushed toward her.

Restate JR followed.

Vonn turned.

He attacked.

BAM!

Restate JR blocked.

Vonn attacked again.

BAM!

Again.

BAM!

Again.

Restate JR caught his arm.

"You are angry."

Vonn glared at him.

"Let go."

"You fight differently when you're angry."

Vonn pulled.

Restate JR held on.

"Let."

Vonn pulled harder.

"GO!"

Restate JR threw him.

Vonn crashed into the ground.

Leafily struggled to stand.

"Vonn..."

Vonn looked at her.

"I'm fine."

"No, you're not."

"I'm fine!"

Leafily ran toward him.

Restate JR watched.

"Interesting."

Leafily reached Vonn.

She placed her hands against him.

"I can heal you."

Vonn shook his head.

"Don't."

"Why?"

"Because he'll attack you."

Leafily smiled.

"Then we'll be quick."

A soft glow surrounded her hands.

Vonn's injuries began to fade.

Restate JR watched.

"That is inconvenient."

Vonn looked up.

"Leafily, move!"

Too late.

Restate JR attacked.

Leafily turned.

The strike hit her.

She was thrown across the cave.

Vonn froze.

For one second—

Everything stopped.

His breathing.

His thoughts.

The noise of the cave.

Everything.

Leafily landed hard.

"Leafily..."

Vonn stared at her.

She tried to move.

"Vonn..."

He didn't answer.

Sparkyle looked at him.

"Vonn?"

Vonn slowly stood.

His fists were shaking.

Not from fear.

From anger.

Restate JR smiled.

"Now I see it."

Vonn looked at him.

"See what?"

"The difference."

A strange energy began moving around Vonn.

Restate JR's smile disappeared.

Vonn's eyes glowed.

Sparkyle stared.

"Vonn..."

Vonne whispered, "What's happening?"

Tulip stepped backward.

"I don't know."

The air around Vonn changed.

The temperature dropped.

The ground beneath his feet began freezing.

A thin layer of ice spread across the stone.

Leafily looked at him.

"Vonn..."

Vonn looked at his own hands.

Ice formed around his fingers.

He stared.

"What..."

Sparkyle stepped closer.

"Your mystic."

Vonn looked at him.

"My what?"

Sparkyle's expression was serious.

"I think you've changed."

Vonn looked toward the frozen ground.

The ice continued spreading.

He clenched his fist.

A sharp crystal formed around his hand.

Restate JR took a step backward.

"Impossible."

Vonn looked at him.

"What's impossible?"

"You were a Water Mystic."

Vonn looked down.

Water gathered briefly around his hand.

Then—

It froze.

The water disappeared into ice.

Vonn stared.

"I..."

He tried again.

Nothing.

No water.

Only ice.

He looked at Sparkyle.

"I can't feel it."

Sparkyle understood.

"Your Water Mystic."

Vonn's eyes widened.

"It's gone."

Nobody spoke.

Vonn looked at his hand again.

Ice crawled across his fingers.

"I lost it."

Leafily slowly approached.

"Vonn..."

Vonn looked at her.

She smiled weakly.

"Maybe..."

She glanced at the ice.

"Maybe you gained something too."

Vonn looked toward Restate JR.

The ice around him grew thicker.

His expression hardened.

"I did."

Restate JR stared.

"What did you become?"

Vonn raised his hand.

A giant sheet of ice erupted from the ground.

KRAAAACK!

Restate JR jumped away.

Vonn shouted:

"Ice Mystic."

The cave became a battlefield of ice.

Vonn slammed his hand down.

A frozen wave raced toward Restate JR.

Restate JR jumped.

The wave struck the wall.

CRASH!

Ice spread across the stone.

Vonn launched another attack.

Restate JR dodged.

"You're faster."

Vonn attacked again.

"And stronger."

Another blast.

"And colder."

Restate JR blocked.

The ice shattered against his arms.

"But you're still only one fighter."

Sparkyle stepped beside Vonn.

"Who said he was alone?"

Vonn looked at him.

Sparkyle smiled.

"Remember?"

Vonn smiled back.

"Vonne Pack."

Vonne stepped forward.

"Together."

Tulip raised her fists.

"Always."

Leafily stood up.

"I'm still here."

Vonn looked at her.

"Are you sure?"

Leafily nodded.

"Absolutely."

She wiped some dust from her face.

"I didn't come this far to sit out the ending."

Sparkyle laughed.

"That's the Leafily I know."

Restate JR looked at all five.

"You really think teamwork will defeat me?"

Vonne answered.

"No."

Restate JR smiled.

"Good."

Vonne continued.

"I think **we** will."

Restate JR's smile disappeared.

"Then come."

Restate JR charged.

Vonn charged too.

The two collided.

BOOM!

Ice and dark energy exploded outward.

Sparkyle moved around the side.

He fired an electrical blast.

Restate JR blocked it.

Vonn struck from above.

Restate JR ducked.

Tulip threw another rock.

Restate JR dodged.

"Why do you keep doing that?"

Tulip smiled.

"Because it keeps working."

"It barely works."

"It distracts you."

Restate JR looked at her.

Tulip pointed.

"Exactly."

Vonne rushed in.

She struck his side.

Restate JR stumbled.

Leafily fired a healing burst toward Vonn.

Vonn's injuries faded.

Sparkyle shouted:

"Now!"

Vonn slammed both hands forward.

A massive ice wall shot upward.

Restate JR was trapped between the ice and the cave wall.

"ENOUGH!"

He released a massive dark shockwave.

The ice shattered.

Vonn flew backward.

Sparkyle caught him.

"Got you!"

Vonn looked at him.

"Thanks."

"No problem."

Restate JR rose from the broken ice.

He looked exhausted.

But he was still standing.

"You are persistent."

Vonne looked at him.

"So are you."

"I don't need persistence."

Restate JR raised his hands.

"I need power."

Dark energy gathered.

The cave began shaking violently.

Rocks fell.

Memphy looked upward.

"Everyone!"

She pointed.

"The cave is collapsing!"

Vonn looked around.

"How long?"

"Not long!"

Tulip shouted, "We need to finish this!"

Sparkyle looked at Restate JR.

"Then let's finish it."

Vonn nodded.

He looked at Sparkyle.

"I have an idea."

Sparkyle grinned.

"I already know."

Vonn raised an eyebrow.

"You do?"

"No."

" ... "

"But it sounded cool."

Vonn laughed.

Even in the middle of the battle.

Even with the cave collapsing.

He laughed.

Then he looked at Restate JR.

"Sparkyle."

"Yeah?"

"Let's do it."

Sparkyle's electricity began crackling.

Vonn's ice spread across the ground.

The two energies began moving toward each other.

Restate JR noticed.

"What are you doing?"

Vonn answered:

"Ending this."

Restate JR charged.

Vonn shouted:

"NOW!"

Sparkyle unleashed electricity.

Vonn unleashed ice.

The two attacks collided.

For a moment—

Nothing happened.

Then—

KRAAAAAA-BOOOOOOM!

Ice and electricity merged.

A gigantic wave of frozen lightning blasted through the cave.

Restate JR raised both arms.

He tried to block.

The wave hit him.

BOOOOOOM!

He was pushed backward.

He dug his feet into the stone.

"No!"

The wave kept coming.

Restate JR screamed:

"I WILL NOT LOSE!"

Vonn shouted:

"ICE-SHOCK!"

Sparkyle shouted:

"ICE-SHOCK!"

The attack became even stronger.

The entire cave lit up.

Blue-white energy filled the chamber.

Restate JR's dark energy cracked.

His defenses broke apart.

He fell to one knee.

"No..."

Vonn stepped forward.

"This region doesn't belong to you."

Restate JR looked up.

"I built everything!"

"You stole everything."

"I continued my father's legacy!"

"You destroyed it."

"I am Restate JR!"

Vonn raised his hand.

"And now you're finished."

The Ice-Shock hit.

BOOOOOOOOOOOM!

Restate JR disappeared into the blast.

The cave went completely white.

Silence.

Then—

Drip.

A tiny piece of melted ice fell.

Drip.

Another.

Vonne opened her eyes.

"Is everyone okay?"

Tulip sat up.

"I think so."

Sparkyle looked around.

"Vonn?"

"I'm here."

Leafily raised her hand.

"I'm okay."

Memphy slowly stood.

"My wing..."

She looked at it.

It was still damaged.

"But I'm alive."

Vonne smiled.

"That's what matters."

Then Sparkyle looked toward the center of the cave.

"Uh..."

Everyone turned.

A huge cloud of energy was still floating there.

Vonn frowned.

"Is that..."

Sparkyle shook his head.

"I don't know."

The cloud began expanding.

Memphy's eyes widened.

"Everyone, move!"

The energy burst outward.

WHOOSH!

But—

It wasn't violent.

It wasn't destructive.

It passed through them like a warm breeze.

Vonn blinked.

"What was that?"

Tulip looked around.

"Nothing happened."

Leafily stared toward the cave entrance.

"Look."

Outside, the sky was changing.

The dark clouds covering the region began disappearing.

Sunlight poured through.

Memphy's eyes widened.

"The region..."

Vonne walked toward the entrance.

The land outside was changing.

The dark structures Restate JR had built were shutting down.

Enemy machines stopped.

Bombelos stopped moving.

Speedos stopped.

Flingos dropped their weapons.

Worms disappeared underground.

Flamines went out.

Spikes stopped.

Even the remaining General Flingos fled.

The region was silent.

Then—

A distant cheer.

Then another.

Then hundreds.

People were coming out of shelters.

They were free.

Restate JR's control was gone.

Sparkyle smiled.

"We did it."

Vonn stared at the sunlight.

"Yeah."

Leafily smiled.

"We actually did it."

Tulip jumped.

"We won!"

Vonne laughed.

"Vonne Pack!"

Everyone shouted together:

"VONNE PACK!"

A few hours later, the region looked completely different.

People were repairing houses.

Families were coming outside.

Children were running through the streets.

The old flags were being put back up.

Memphy walked through the crowd with Vonne Pack.

Her damaged wing was still folded against her side.

But she was smiling.

A little VONS child ran up to her.

"Memphy!"

Memphy bent down.

"Hey."

"Did you defeat Restate JR?"

Memphy looked at Vonne Pack.

Then smiled.

"We all did."

The child looked at Vonn.

"Was it you?"

Vonn shook his head.

"It was all of us."

The child looked at Sparkyle.

"What about you?"

Sparkyle proudly raised his hand.

"I did the electricity."

Vonn looked at him.

"We both did the final attack."

Sparkyle nodded.

"Exactly."

The child looked at Leafily.

"And you?"

Leafily smiled.

"I kept everyone alive."

Tulip pointed at herself.

"And I threw rocks."

Everyone stared at her.

Tulip shrugged.

"They were useful."

Vonne laughed.

"Sometimes."

Later, Memphy called everyone to the center of the region.

Vonne Pack stood together.

Memphy held something behind her back.

Sparkyle narrowed his eyes.

"What is that?"

"Wait."

"Is it food?"

"No."

"A bomb?"

"No."

"A smaller bomb?"

"No!"

Sparkyle sighed.

"Okay."

Memphy smiled.

She brought out a small whistle.

"This is for you."

Vonn took it.

"A whistle?"

"It's a call whistle."

Memphy explained:

"If you ever need help, blow it."

Vonn looked at it.

"What happens?"

Memphy smiled.

"You'll find out."

Sparkyle leaned closer.

"Can I blow it now?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because you're standing next to my ear."

"Oh."

Sparkyle moved away.

"Fair."

Memphy then brought out the costumes.

The glider costume.

The spiky costume.

The underwater costume.

She held them up.

Vonn stared at the glider.

Leafily stared at the spiky costume.

Sparkyle stared at the underwater costume.

Vonne and Tulip watched.

Memphy smiled.

"These belong to you now."

Vonn took the glider costume.

Leafily took the spiky costume.

Sparkyle took the underwater costume.

Vonne looked at them.

"So we're keeping these?"

Memphy nodded.

"Yes."

Tulip smiled.

"Looks like you three have new equipment."

Sparkyle immediately put on the underwater costume.

"Can I test it?"

Vonn sighed.

"Please don't jump into anything."

Sparkyle looked toward a nearby fountain.

"...Too late."

"SPARKYLE!"

He ran.

Everyone laughed.

Memphy looked at the group.

For the first time in a long time—

She wasn't afraid.

The region was free.

The people were safe.

Restate JR was gone.

And Vonne Pack had survived.

Vonn looked at the others.

Vonne.

Tulip.

Leafily.

Sparkyle.

Then he looked down at his hands.

Ice shimmered around his fingers.

He tried to summon water.

Nothing happened.

He looked at the ice again.

His Water Mystic was gone.

Permanently.

But his Ice Mystic remained.

He smiled.

"Guess things changed."

Leafily walked over.

"Are you okay with it?"

Vonn thought for a moment.

Then nodded.

"Yeah."

He looked at the sky.

"I think I am."

Sparkyle came running back.

"GOOD NEWS!"

Everyone turned.

"What?"

"I can swim faster!"

Vonne laughed.

"You tested it already?"

"Obviously."

Tulip shook her head.

"You really have no patience."

"Nope."

Vonn laughed.

Then he raised the whistle Memphis had given him.

"Everyone ready?"

Vonne grinned.

"Ready."

Tulip nodded.

Leafily smiled.

Sparkyle raised both hands.

"READY!"

Vonn blew the whistle.

FFFFFFFFFFFFFFFF!

The sound traveled across the region.

People looked up.

Some smiled.

Some waved.

Memphy looked at the group.

"Vonne Pack."

Vonn smiled.

"Yeah?"

Memphy pointed toward the open road.

"Where are you going next?"

Vonn looked at the others.

Nobody knew.

Not yet.

Vonne smiled.

"Wherever the next problem is."

Sparkyle jumped onto Vonn's back.

"Hopefully somewhere with snacks."

Leafily laughed.

Tulip rolled her eyes.

Vonne shook her head.

And Memphy laughed too.

The five began walking.

Behind them was the region they had saved.

Ahead of them was the unknown.

And for the first time—

The unknown didn't feel scary.

It felt like another adventure.

The Vonne Pack walked on.

Together.

And this time, nobody was left behind.

THE END